

THE PAST MASTERS (clockwise from left) A *baithak* during *Drawing '94*; opening of the G.R. Iranna show; M.F. Husain paints as Renu Modi looks on

in July 2025. The gallery has long been a champion of the late Indian-American artist, whose minimalist works on woodcuts and intaglio prints abstractly depicting cityscapes and urban life earned her global recognition. The gallery will also release two books of essays to commemorate the landmark year.

"I have never been in competition with any other gallery, and have always been motivated by my passion and commitment to just show art in the right perspective," says Modi, underlining the gallery's aim to make art exciting and conversational. In the past, it has hosted exhibitions like *Kitsch Kitsch Hota Hai* (2001) dealing with pop and kitsch in contemporary art; *Leela* (2003), inspired by a residency with Bhupen Khakhar, Amit Ambalal, Atul and Anju Dodiya in Haridwar; *Lo Real Maravilloso* (2009), dealing with magic realism in art, and two editions of *Video Wednesday* (2008-09 and 2011-12), a year-long video-art festival. With these projects, Gallery Espace had aimed to trigger a dialogue on the myriad possibilities art holds. Decades later, it is still pushing the creative envelope with just as much fervour. ■

–Arshia

ART

Winds of Change

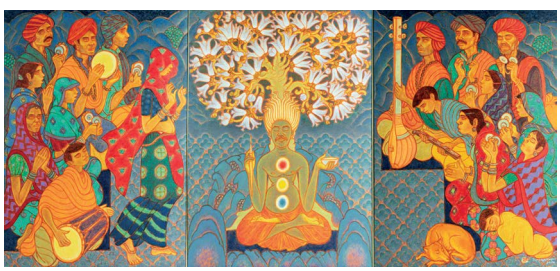
An exhibition at KNMA Noida looks back at the history of art education in India

Purvaee, or the eastern wind, at KNMA Noida explores how the first generation of artist-pedagogues from different art institutions transmitted their creative sensibility and represented themselves visually. The exhibition, subtitled *Evoking Pedagogic Lineages*, focuses on the country's two pioneering art institutions—Kala Bhavana in Santiniketan and the Faculty of Fine Arts in Baroda.

Featuring more than 200 rarely seen and historically significant pieces from the museum collection, the exhibition displays works produced between the 1940s and 2000s by 14 artists. A bonus is the critically acclaimed work 'Sati', a Japanese woodblock print by Nandalal Bose from the early 20th century. Through a non-sequential arrangement of artworks, the exhibition aims to explore relationships between individual practices, cross-generational creative conversations and institutional quirks.

"*Purvaee* alludes to the dynamic nature of natural wonders like monsoon winds, which change environments by bringing in fresh flora and life. The core narrative of this show is derived from the masters' practices, which converse with the artistic practices of subsequent generations. Many of these students have gone on to make important contributions to the field of modern and contemporary art," says Avijna Bhattacharya, who curated the exhibition and has attended both institutions herself.





CANVAS CHRONICLES A. Ramachandran's 'In Trance', 2008; (top) an untitled work by K.G. Subramanyan, 1952

THE SHOW DISPLAYS WORKS PRODUCED BY 14 ARTISTS BETWEEN THE 1940s AND 2000s

Manisha Gera Baswani's body of work, featured here, was born from prolonged illness and acupuncture needles repeatedly puncturing her skin for days on end. Furiously and almost driven, she started repeatedly incising and perforating large and small sheets of watercolour paper of varying sizes with sharp pins in her studio. As the perforations transformed the paper surface, bringing life and beauty to it, she began to find deep solace in the act of pinning paper. "I couldn't help but draw parallels between the repeated narrations of the Partition stories of my parents and my working process. Pain and healing had become simultaneous. They became light boxes when I realised that acupuncture was bringing light into my being and allowing for recovery," she says.

Bhagat Singh's work draws inspiration among other things from Indian folk, miniature and mural culture. His paintings—'Spring', 'The Beauty of Nature', 'Banana Tree', 'Peace', and 'Sponge Gourd Creeper'—aim to tell viewers that nature is beautiful and essential for life. "Nature is our strength, and gives us air, food and water. We should not destroy it," says the artist. ■

– Neha Kirpal

Purvaee will continue at the Kiran Nadar Museum of Art, Noida, till Feb. 20, 2025